Venezuela: Talking Points (Grades 5-6)

Video: about 8 minutes. Simple words.

Words to know

- Independence: a country rules itself.
- Dictator: a leader with all the power, chosen without a fair vote.
- Democracy: people vote to choose their leaders.
- Socialism: the government controls much of the money and businesses.
- Inflation: prices go up fast.
- Emancipation: setting people free.

The story

- Long ago: Indigenous people lived here. Columbus came in 1498. Spain ruled, and Caracas was founded in 1567. Venezuela may mean "Little Venice."
- Simón Bolívar, "El Libertador," led the fight for independence from Spain. The Battle of Carabobo in 1821 freed Venezuela.
- 1854: a law signed by President José Gregorio Monagas ended slavery.
- Indigenous, African and European people mixed their food, music and ideas: arepas, joropo, Spanish.
- Angel Falls is the tallest waterfall in the world. Venezuela has more oil than any other country.
- 1958: the last dictator left and democracy began.
- Golden age (1958 to 1983): oil money, big cities, free music lessons (El Sistema), baseball stars.
- From 1999, Hugo Chávez and later Nicolás Maduro: socialism, close friendship with Fidel Castro of Cuba, high prices, little food and medicine.
- How rights were taken away, step by step (UN and human rights groups): unfair courts, a TV channel shut down, no limit on staying in power, food used to reward supporters, protesters arrested. In 2017 the voting company Smartmatic said the turnout number was at least one million votes too high.
- Nearly 8 million people left Venezuela. Many went to Colombia, Peru, Brazil, Chile and the U.S. (Florida). Families were split up.
- January 2026: the U.S. captured Maduro and took him to New York. Prosecutors charged him with drug crimes and, in October, with torture, including of American citizens. UN investigators found serious crimes by his government. He is in U.S. custody, waiting for a trial. María Corina Machado won the Nobel Peace Prize in 2025 and came home on October 25, 2026.
- Elections are expected in 2027, but the date is not set yet.

Questions to ask

- What would you pack if you had to move to a new country?
- Why is voting important?
- What foods and music does your family share?

Sources: Reuters, AP, UNHCR, U.S. EIA, UN Fact-Finding Mission, Human Rights Watch. Prepared Oct 28, 2026.